

Spain has halted Eisenman's cultural city project in Santiago

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Peter Eisenman



Madrid - The parliament of the northern Spanish region of Galicia this week definitively halted the massive "City of Culture" project at the famous pilgrimage site in Santiago de Compostela for financial reasons. The plans of renowned American architect Peter Eisenman will remain incomplete, as only a portion of his vision has been realized over the past 12 years. The region aims to save 170 million euros by ending the construction, which has so far cost around 300 million euros, reported the APA agency.

The City of Culture project (Cidade da Cultura) has been debated in Spain for several years, but its fate has long been unclear. The construction is considered a symbol of waste in the country, as costs have far exceeded the original budget. The cornerstone of the complex was laid in 2001, with expectations that the construction would take three years and cost 108 million euros. However, over 290 million euros have been spent to date, with two of the planned six buildings still left to be completed.

A sort of "cultural acropolis" was to be created on a hill on the outskirts of Santiago de Compostela. Today, it features a library, a museum, an archive, and an administrative building, while the international art center and concert hall will not be built due to the decision of lawmakers. It remains uncertain whether the empty plots will be utilized in the future.

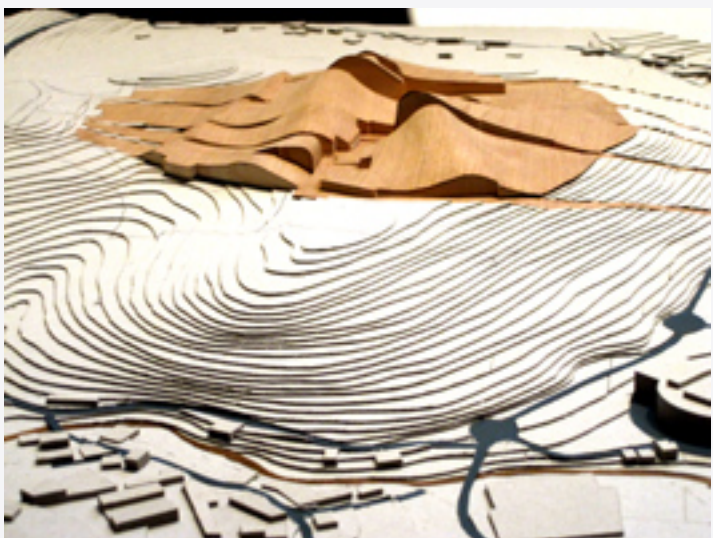
Galicia, like the rest of Spain, is facing an economic crisis that now does not favor such expansive projects. In recent years, however, the Spanish have spent billions of euros on cultural buildings. The success of the extravagant Guggenheim Museum building in Bilbao, which attracted millions of tourists to the city after its construction, has served as inspiration for them.

For example, in the northern Spanish city of Avilés, the Oscar Niemeyer Center opened two years ago. The Mediterranean city of Valencia spent about 1.3 billion euros on the "City of Arts and Sciences" project, which included the construction of a new opera building according to the plans of architect Santiago Calatrava.

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